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“PREVENTION IS BETTER than cure.” In the 16th century, Dutch philosopher Desiderius Erasmus coined the immortal phrase that today manifests the business model of a spurt of start-ups focussed on preventive healthcare. The core message: stay fit, eat healthy, live healthy, and show diseases the door, especially non-communicable diseases (NCDs) such as cardiovascular diseases (heart attack, stroke), chronic respiratory diseases (lung cancer, cystic fibrosis), diabetes, etc. If you have a consistently unhealthy diet, don’t exercise, or you smoke or drink, you are at greater risk of attracting these diseases, big killers all.

What should you do? Well, you would know that answer. But what you may not know is: the right food to eat, right exercise for you, right lifestyle habits. A burgeoning segment of the population wants to know these facts, and act on them, forming a community of sorts that has become a big market for business. And start-ups such as Cult.fit, HealthifyMe, Fitterfly, Pristyn Care and Mfine, among many others, are jumping in with an array of experts from fitness maestros to dieticians and gadgets such as fitness trackers and health-monitoring devices to help you do what is right for you. Backed by big money from venture capitalists and snazzy tech-led platforms, these start-ups offer a multitude of solutions that are pumped up through cool marketing campaigns.

Experts believe that such preventive healthcare start-ups have the potential to mitigate India’s burden of NCDs with their innovations and technology-led solutions. “Preventive healthtech start-ups

can certainly play a role in mitigating the disease burden in the country,” says Dr Anoop Misra, Chairman of Fortis-CDOC hospital in Delhi. “Patients are also more aware about their health and are using several app-based services to monitor their basic health parameters.”

You get an idea of just how big the ‘burden’ is when you see the stats: NCDs’ contribution to all deaths in India shot up to 61.8 per cent in 2016 from 37.9 per cent in 1990, according to a study by the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR). That has increased to 70 per cent in 2022, as per independent data platform Statista.

“The burden of chronic diseases has been rising steadily in the country and patients are also more aware that untreated diabetes, hypertension, chronic obstructive pulmonary disease (an inflammatory lung disease), etc. can be very risky,” says Dr Hema Venkataraman, Medical Advisor-New Offerings at Practo, an online doctor consultation app. “The curative healthcare market is going to struggle to keep up with the rise of chronic diseases. So, turning to preventive healthcare is inevitable and the need of the hour.”

Ironically, it was a communicable disease—Covid-19—that set this trend afire. The two years and more of the pandemic taught all of us the need to look after ourselves through healthy lifestyles and food habits. “Covid-19 presented an unprecedented fillip to the healthcare revolution

THE WARM-UP



► The overall domestic preventive healthcare market was estimated to be around \$93 billion in 2021



► The preventive healthcare market is expected to reach \$197 billion by 2025, growing at an annualised rate of 22 per cent



► Global mobility, rising education and income levels, the availability of internet and tech-led innovations are some of the key growth drivers for healthcare start-ups



► Healthtech start-ups are tapping into the preventive health opportunity across segments such as nutrition management, lifestyle monitoring, health check-ups, and mental and physical wellness



► Government support is another growth driver. In 2021, it had said it would launch an incentive scheme to support 75 start-ups in the areas of telemedicine, digital health and AI